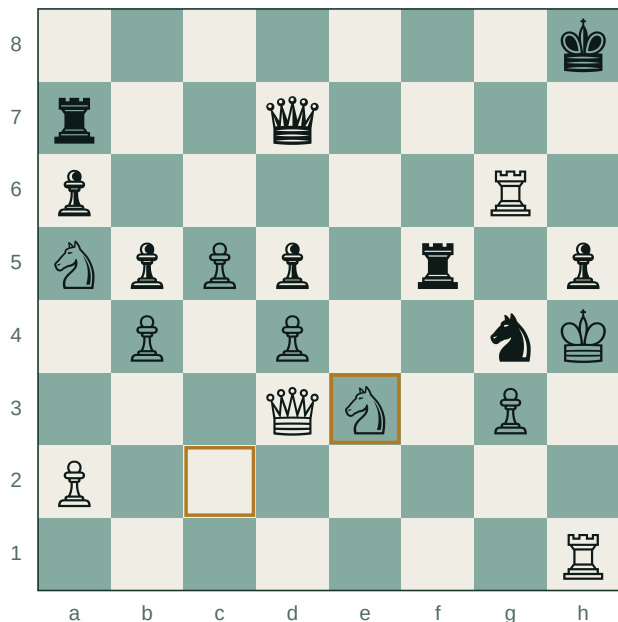


Active defensive resources: Black, move 36

Active defensive resources

Black to move



Previous move: 36.Ne3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

36...Qe7+ 37. Kh3 Nf2+ 38. Kh2 Nxd3 39. Rh6+ Kg8

36...Qe7+ Check restricts White to 3 legal replies here. From e7 it attacks king on h4 and knight on e3. Recorded reply: **37.Kh3**.

37...Nf2+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. From f2 it attacks king on h3, queen on d3 and rook on h1. Recorded reply: **38.Kh2**.

38...Nxd3 The knight captures the queen on d3. Recorded reply: **39.Rh6+**.

39...Kg8 The king moves from h8 to g8.

At the end, nominal material is White 21 / Black 26 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +9. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +9**: the balance goes from -4 to +5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on h4. Geometrically undefended: rook on g6 and queen on d3. Check for tactical protection.